

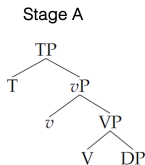
Empirical Perspectives on the Object Agreement Cycle analysis of different varieties of Spanish

Philippa Adolf

Hispanistentag 2025
13 March

- 1 Previous accounts: The Object Agreement Cycle
- 2 Clitic doubling and null objects in Spanish
- 3 Research questions
- 4 Corpus-based study of CD and NOs throughout Spanish diachrony
- 5 Results
- 6 The Clitic Doubling Cycle as an alternative?
- 7 Next steps
- 8 References

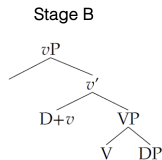
The Object Agreement Cycle¹



analysis Object pronoun = DP [iφ, uAsp]

structures only CLLD possible

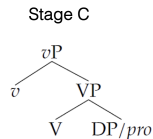
varieties Old Spanish



Object pronoun/clitic =
DP/D [iφ, uAsp]; v [uφ, iAsp]

CLLD and ACD possible

Standard Spanish



Object clitic = v [uφ, iAsp]

CLLD + epithets, ACD, and
NROs possible

Rioplatense Spanish

Figure: Overview of the OAC

¹Maddox 2021

Clitic doubling

CD as the co-appearance of a clitic and a correlative syntagma in the canonical position of the object within the same sentence²

- distinction from dislocated structures: in "true" clitic doubling, the DO argument appears in canonical position³
- serves as an indication of high degree of shared accessibility to the referent, a raised degree of affectedness on the direct object, and a raised degree of importance or salience attributed to the event⁴

²Gómez Seibane 2023

³Gabriel and Rinke 2010

⁴David 2014

- (1) a. (RS, ES)
Pedro la vio a él.
- b. (RS, *ES?)
Pedro lo vio a Juan.
- (2) a. (RS, *ES)
Lo vi el camión.
- b. (RS, *ES)
A María, la vi [a esa loca] el jueves.

European Spanish (ES)

- obligatory CD with personal pronouns, optional with other types of pronouns⁵
- no CD of accusative NPs⁶

Rioplatense Spanish (RS)

- less restricted with regard to CD of NPs⁷
- allows CD with epithets, complex NPs⁸

⁵Gabriel and Rinke 2010

⁶Masullo 2020

⁷Estigarribia 2006; Rinke, Elsig, and Wieprecht 2020

⁸Suñer 2006

Null objects

A phonologically unrealised DO argument⁹

- comprises many different phenomena: argument ellipsis, empty categories, object drop¹⁰
- syntactic and semantic status of null object realisation in Spanish underexplored¹¹
 - anaphoric/non-anaphoric uses
 - indefinite NOs vs. definite NOs¹²
 - NOs in coordination, subordination, syntactic islands in Portuguese (→ in Spanish?)

⁹Barbosa 2024

¹⁰Cyrino 2019

¹¹Alamillo and S. Schwenter 2007

¹²Cyrino 2017; Martínez-García 2024

(3) a. (RS, ES)

¿Compraste café? - Sí, compré.

b. (RS, *ES)

Una porción para llevar. ¿Calentamos un poco?

(4) a. (RS, ES)

María trajo diez libros, y Pedro también trajo.

b. (RS, *ES)

Queremos el postre. - Ya traigo.

European Spanish (ES)

- possible when omitted anaphoric referent is a mass noun or a bare noun/bare plural¹³
- NOs in coordination sometimes possible¹⁴
- possibility of propositional objects (neuter clitic *lo*)¹⁵

Rioplatense Spanish (RS)

- less restricted with regard to NOs of indefinite referents¹⁶
- allows cases of definite object drop (like Portuguese)¹⁷

¹³Campos 1986

¹⁴Barbosa 2024

¹⁵Alamillo and S. Schwenter 2007

¹⁶Masullo 2020

¹⁷S. Schwenter 2006

Variation Gap¹⁸

structure	ES	RS	EP	BP
CD	✓	✓	×	(✓)
NOs	×	(✓)	✓	✓

Table: Overview of distributions of CD and NOs in varieties of Spanish and Portuguese (EP = European Portuguese; BP = Brazilian Portuguese/Mineiro Portuguese)

How can we explain this variation?

→ diachronic approaches as a way to account for synchronic variation

¹⁸Parrott 2006

The Object Agreement Cycle (Maddox 2021)

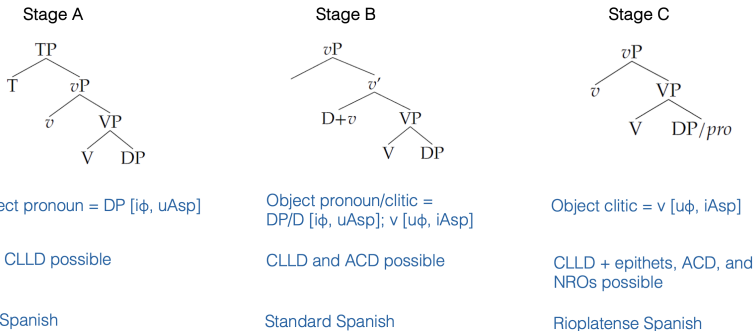


Figure: Overview of the OAC

Main point: NOs only possible in varieties where ACD is established beforehand

	Old Spanish	Conservative Modern Spanish	Rioplatense Spanish
Clitic-left dislocation	✓	✓	✓
Accusative clitic doubling	×	(✓)	✓
Null referential objects	(×)	(×)	✓

Table: Different configurations of CLLD, ACD, and NRO in Spanish varieties, adapted from Maddox (2021)

Strengths

- connects CD and NOs as different ways of DO realisation

Limitations

- no clear definitions of NOs
- claims of cross-linguistic explanatory power; however: developed on the basis of Spanish data; Portuguese?
- no integration of semantic or information-structural constraints of CD and NOs
- strict separation of accusative and dative objects; warranted for Spanish?
- lack of robust empirical data

RQ1 What are the frequencies of doubled and omitted DOs in Spanish diachrony?

Expectations based on the OAC:

- no NOs before the emergence of ACD
- overall no anaphoric NOs in ES (only possible in RS)
- delay between the emergence of CLLD (medieval Spanish) and ACD (contemporary varieties of Spanish)

RQ2 Can the alternation between realisation, doubling, and omission be explained by the verbal semantics of transitive structures?

RQ3 What are the semantic properties of doubled DOs and NOs?

→ empirical data on the diachrony of different ways of direct object realisation

Goals (RQ1): frequency of DO doubling, (IO doubling), and NOs

- between the 12th and 20th century in ES
- between the 18th and 20th century in RS

Approach: verb-based¹⁹

- transitive structures involving 50-60 verbs
- selection of verbs based on
 - the frequency within each subcorpus (lemma)
 - overall diachronic stability (e.g. verbs used throughout the different periods)
- types of verbs included
 - < transitives: *hacer, llevar, querer, echar*, etc.
 - < ditransitives: *dar, prestar, vender, mostrar*, etc.
 - perception verbs²⁰ : *oír, ver, amar, temer, esperar, olvidar*, etc.

¹⁹Goldberg 2005; Heusinger 2008; Von Heusinger and Kaiser 2011

²⁰Vega Vilanova 2022

Compilation of subcorpora:

- collection of texts used in previous corpus-based studies²¹
- register: spoken/as close to spoken as possible (cantares, dramas, texts including direct speech)
- size of subcorpora: between 40.000 and 250.000 words

Annotated subcorpora (thus far):

cent.	text	type	size
12th c.	Fazienda Ultramar	prose, travel guide	86.000
13th c.	Cantar de Mio Çid	verse, cantar	40.000
14th c.	El Conde Lucanor	prose, exempla	88.000

Table: Overview of subcorpora (Spanish, 12th-14th centuries)

²¹V. Belloro 2007; Flores Cervantes and Melis 2004; Gómez Seibane 2023; Rinke, Elsig, and Wieprecht 2020; Gabriel and Rinke 2010; Company Company 2004

- automised:
 - Python, R: cleaning up texts and data frames
 - Sketch Engine: extraction of transitive structures + left and right context (100 characters) using CQL

- manual:
 - removal of negative hits (passives, reflexives, causatives, prepositional arguments, etc.)
 - annotation of object realisation
 - DO PREVERBAL, DO POSTVERBAL
 - DO PREVERBAL, DO POSTVERBAL
 - DO DOUBLING, DOUBLING TYPE
 - DO DOUBLING, DOUBLING TYPE
 - NULL DO, TYPE

→ between 1100 and 1500 transitive structures eligible for analysis

Summary of results for CD in ES and RS²²

CD	type	13th cent.	15th cent.	16th cent.	17th cent.	18th cent.	19th cent.	20th cent.	contemp.
IO	nominal	22/343 (6%)		34/336 (10%)		172/430 (40%)		505/609 (83%)	2106/2600 (81%)
	general	2/30 (7%)	2/20 (10%)	33/512 (6%)	287/809 (35%)	206/817 (55%)	437/796 (55%)		
DO	nominal								130/2600 (0.5%)
	general								15/125 (12%)
IO + DO			11/160 (7%)	21/61 (34%)	46/100 (46%)	83/150 (55%)			

Table: CD in ES

CD	type	20th cent.	contemp.
IO	nominal		710/780 (91%)
	general	78/520 (15%)	
DO	nominal		81/2300 (3.5%)
	general	56/1400 (4%)	9/80 (11%)
IO + DO			269/2105 (13%)

Table: CD in RS

²²V. Belloro 2007; V. A. Belloro 2012; Barrechega Orrechia 1997; Flores Cervantes and Melis 2004; Gómez Seibane 2023; Rinke, Elsig, and Wieprecht 2020; Gabriel and Rinke 2010

CD	type	12th cent.	13th. cent	14th cent.
IO	nominal	0/368 (0.0%)	13/265 (5.0%)	16/411 (4.0%)
	pronominal	0/368 (0.0%)	6/265 (2.0%)	21/411 (5.0%)
	general	0/368 (0.0%)	19/265 (7.0%)	37/411 (9.0%)
DO	nominal	1/737 (0.2%)	11/1043 (1.0%)	13/1208 (1.1%)
	pronominal	0/737 (0.0%)	13/1043 (1.0%)	29/1208 (2.4%)
	clausal	0/737 (0.0%)	6/1043 (0.6%)	11/1208 (0.9%)
	general	1/737 (0.2%)	30/1043 (2.6%)	53/1208 (4.4%)

Table: Preliminary results CD

Main observations:

- no CD of any objects up until the 13th century
- IO doubling is more frequent than DO doubling
- both IO and DO doubling increase

- (5) a. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid [#ID36154])
¡Agora las ayan quitas heredades de Carrión!
- b. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid [#ID5329])
Non lo saben los moros el ardiment que an.
- c. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid [#ID31418])
Nos bien la sabemos aquesta rrazón que derecho demanda el Çid Campeador.
- d. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid [#ID34054])
Los CC marcos al rrey los soltó.
- e. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid [#ID3622])
La oraçión fecha, la missa acabada la an, [...]

Summary of results for NOs in Spanish

NOs	type	12th cent.	13th cent.	14th cent.
DO	anaphoric			
	non-anaphoric			
	general	93/1534 (6.0%)	45/1115 (3.0%)	46/1424 (3.2%)

Table: Preliminary results NOs

Main points:

- NOs in Spanish less restricted at older stages
- the frequency of NOs decreases

- (6) a. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid, #ID25701)
el padre con las fijas loran de coraçón assí fazían los cavalleros del
Campeador.
- b. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid, #ID34663)
otrosí farán a los del Canpeador.
- c. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid, #ID15325)
él sedíe en Valençia curiando & guardando ca bien sabe que Álbar Fánnez
trahe todo rrecabdo.
- d. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid, #ID31099)
el espada tomó & rreçibió.
- e. (13th cent., Cantar de Mio Çid, #ID11270)
rrobavan el campo & piéssanse de tomar.

Main claim: NOs are licensed in a variety if ACD is already licensed as well

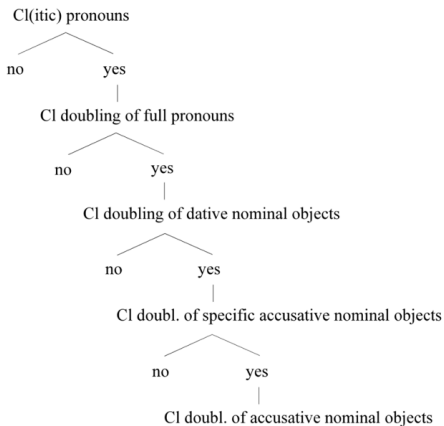
→ rejection of the OAC analysis based on empirical data on Spanish object realisation

Justification:

- NOs possible before the regularisation of CD
- NOs used to be more frequent than CD structures at older stages of Spanish
- NOs decreased when CD increased; implication of competence instead of transitional relationship

→ possible vulnerable period prior to the 15th century of NOs and CD as competing strategies with object realisation; slowly noticeable preference for CD and rejection of NOs

Parameter hierarchy building on Baker (2008: 3), (see also Roberts 2011)



- combining verb-movement and grammaticalisation
- integration of both IOs and DOs
- integration of different doubled categories
- based on and confirmed by empirical data

Figure: The CDC, (Fischer and Rinke 2013)

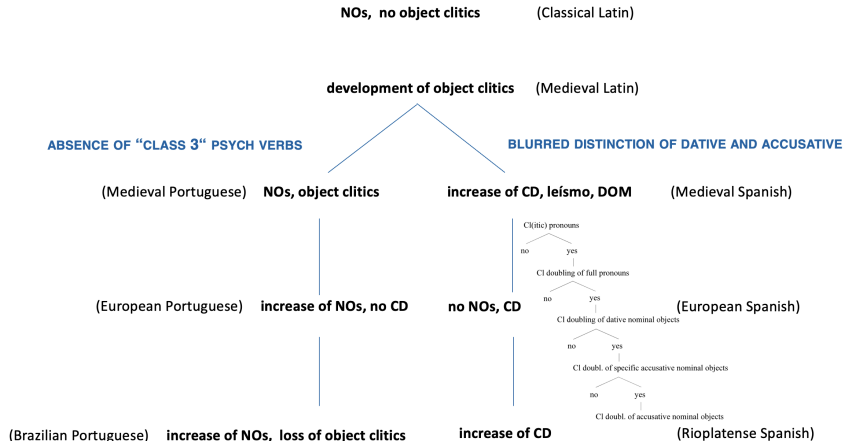


Figure: Development of object realisation in varieties of Portuguese and Spanish

Further annotation

- annotation of remaining data
 - 15th-20th centuries
 - Portuguese data
- integration and coding of additional variables
- object semantics
 - ANIMACY
 - DEFINITENESS
- coding of concurrent phenomena
 - DOM
 - leísmo
 - presence of a referential adverb (*así*, *ya*, etc.)

Statistical analysis:

- influence of object semantics (animacy, definiteness)
- influence of verbal semantics (selection preferences, transitivity)
- productivity of CD/NO structures depending on verbs (based on type frequencies)

¡Gracias!

comments, tips, direct/indirect *objections*?

-  Alamillo, Reig & Scott Schwenter. 2007. Null Objects and Neuter Lo: A Cross-Dialectal Variationist Analysis. *Selected Proceedings of the Third Workshop on Spanish Sociolinguistics*, 113–121.
-  Barbosa, Pilar. Sept. 25, 2024. Null Objects, Null Nominal Anaphora and Antilogophoricity. *Probus* 36(2), 251–281.
-  Belloro, Valeria. 2007. *Spanish Clitic Doubling: A Study of the Syntax-Pragmatics Interface*. State University of New York.
-  Belloro, Valeria A. 2012. Pronombres Clíticos, Dislocaciones Y Doblados En Tres Dialectos Del Español. *Nueva Revista de Filología Hispánica* 60(2), 391–424.
-  Campos, Héctor. 1986. Indefinite Object Drop. *Linguistic Inquiry* 17(2), 354–359.
-  Company Company, Concepción. June 30, 2004. ¿Gramaticalización o Desgramaticalización? El Reanálisis y Subjetivación de Verbos Como Marcadores Discursivos En La Historia Del Español. *Revista de Filología Española* 84(1), 29–66.
-  Cyrino, Sonia. 1997. *O objeto nulo no português do Brasil: uma abordagem diacrônica*. Portuguese. Campinas, Brazil: Editora Unicamp.
-  — 2017. The Null Object in Romania Nova. In Kato, Mary A. & Francisco Ordonez (Eds.), *The Morphosyntax of Portuguese and Spanish in Latin America*. Oxford Academic.
-  — 2019. Indefinite Null Objects in Spanish and Brazilian Portuguese. *Caderno de Squibs Temas em estudos formais da linguagem* 5(2), 14–26.

-  David, Oana A. Dec. 21, 2014. Subjectification in the Development of Clitic Doubling: A Diachronic Study of Romanian and Spanish. *Annual Meeting of the Berkeley Linguistics Society* 40, 42.
-  Estigarribia, Bruno. 2006. Why Clitic Doubling? A Functional Analysis for Rioplatense Spanish. *Selected Proceedings of the 8th Hispanic Linguistics Symposium*.
-  Fischer, Susanne & Esther Rinke. Dec. 1, 2013. Explaining the Variability of Clitic Doubling across Romance: A Diachronic Account. *Linguistische Berichte (LB)* 2013(236), 70–87.
-  Flores Cervantes, Marcela & Chantal Melis. July 1, 2004. La Variación Diatópica En El Uso Del Objeto Indirecto Duplicado. *Nueva Revista de Filología Hispánica (NRFH)* 52(2), 329–354.
-  Gabriel, Christoph & Esther Rinke. Aug. 20, 2010. Information Packaging and the Rise of Clitic Doubling in the History of Spanish. In Ferraresi, Gisella & Rosemarie Lühr (Eds.), *Diachronic Studies on Information Structure*, 63–86. DE GRUYTER.
-  Goldberg, Adele E. 2005. Argument Realization: The Role of Constructions, Lexical Semantics, and Discourse Factors. In Östman, Jan-Ola & Mirjam Fried (Eds.), *Construction Grammars: Cognitive Grounding and Theoretical Extensions*. Vol. 3, 17–43. Amsterdam: John Benjamins Publishing Company.
-  Gómez Seibane, Sara. Nov. 16, 2023. Dative Doubling in Non-Mandatory Contexts in European Spanish. *Languages* 8(4), 270.
-  Heusinger, Klaus von. 2008. Verbal semantics and the diachronic development of DOM in Spanish. *Probus* 20(1), 1–31.

-  Luraghi, Silvia. 2004. Null Objects in Latin and Greek and the Relevance of Linguistic Typology for Language Reconstruction. In *Proceedings of the Fifteenth Annual UCLA Indo-European Conference*. Ed. by Karlene Jones-Bley et al. Vol. 49. Washington, D.C.: Institute for the Study of Man, 234–256.
-  Maddox, Matthew. Mar. 30, 2021. Accusative Clitics, Null Objects, and the Object Agreement Cycle. *Journal of Historical Syntax*, 1–56 Pages.
-  Martínez-García, Carlos. 2024. Null Objects in Spanish Recipes (to Appear in Verba. Anuario Galego de Filoloxía 2025).
-  Masullo, Pascual José. Oct. 20, 2020. Interfaz Sintaxis-Pragmática: Caída de Objeto Acusativo Definido Sin Clítico En El Español Rioplatense. *Saga. Revista de Letras* (7), 53–72.
-  Parrott, Jeffrey K. 2006. Distributed Morphological Mechanisms of Pronoun-Case Variation. *University of Pennsylvania Working Papers in Linguistics* 12(2), 173–187.
-  Rinke, Esther, Martin Elsig, & Judith Wieprecht. July 17, 2020. Clitic Doubling in Peninsular and Rioplatense Spanish: A Comparative Corpus Investigation. *Isogloss. Open Journal of Romance Linguistics* 5.
-  Sainzmaza-Lecanda, Lorena & Scott A. Schwenter. May 31, 2017. Null Objects with and without Bilingualism in the Portuguese- and Spanish-speaking World. In. *Issues in Hispanic and Lusophone Linguistics*, 95–121. Amsterdam: John Benjamins Publishing Company.
-  Schwenter, Scott. 2006. Null Objects across South America. *Selected Proceedings of the 8th Hispanic Linguistics Symposium*. Ed. by Timothy Face & Carol Klee, 23–36.
-  Suñer, Margarita. Jan. 20, 2006. Left Dislocations with and without Epithets. *Probus* 18(1).



Vega Vilanova, Jorge. Dec. 19, 2022. On Psych Verbs and Optional Clitic Doubling in Catalan and Other Ibero-Romance Languages. *Catalan Journal of Linguistics* 21, 27–46.



Von Heusinger, Klaus & Georg A. Kaiser. Oct. 2011. Affectedness and Differential Object Marking in Spanish. *Morphology* 21(3-4), 593–617.

- (7) a. Medieval Portuguese, Cantigas (possible in modern BP and EP)
sei eu da mia senhor bem pois me nunca deu; [...]
- b. Medieval Spanish, Poema de Mio Çid (* in modern ES)
Los vassallos de Mío Çid sin piedad les davan, [...].
- (8) a. Medieval Portuguese, Cantigas (possible in MBP and MEP)
E assi faz tod' omen namorado, [...]
- b. Medieval Spanish, Poema de Mio Çid (* in MES)
assí fazían los cavaliers del Campeador.

Summary of results for NOs in Portuguese²⁴

NOs	type	contemp.
DO	anaphoric non-anaphoric general	368/920 (40.0%)

Table: NOs in EP

NOs	type	contemp.
DO	anaphoric non-anaphoric general	900/1250 (72.0%)

Table: NOs in BP

NOs	type	16th cent.	17th cent.	18th cent.	19th cent.	20th cent.
DO	anaphoric non-anaphoric general	32/290 (11.0%)	37/290 (13.0%)	53/280 (19.0%)	121/270 (45.0%)	191/244 (79.0%)

Table: NOs in BP

²⁴ Alamillo and S. Schwenter 2007; S. Schwenter 2006; Sainzmaza-Lecanda and S. A. Schwenter 2017; Cyrino 1997

example Sketch Engine query:

```
[lemma="hacer"] | [word="fa[zg]?[aeiou]*fiz|fizo|far[eiá].*|fag.*|fizi.*"] |
([word="av[ie](a|as|amos|ades|an)|he|has|ha|avemos|avedes|han|avré?|
avrá?|avremos?|avredes?|avrán|avr[ie].*|ay[aei].*|ovi.*"] [word="fech[ao]s?"] ) | ([word="fech[ao]s?" ]
[word="l[ao]s?" ] [word="av[ie](a|as|amos|ades|an)|he|has|ha|avemos|avedes|han|avré?|avrá?|
avremos?|avredes?|avrán|avr[ie].*|ay[aei].*|ovi.*"] ) | ([word="l[ao]s?" ]
[word="av[ie](a|as|amos|ades|an)|he|has|ha|avemos|avedes|han|avré?|avrá?|
avremos?|avredes?|avrán|avr[ie].*|ay[aei].*|ovi.*"] [ ] [word="fech[ao]s?"] )
```